

Melbourne Sustainable Start.

Helping international students practise everyday sustainability in a new city — through peers, not lectures.

THE PROBLEM

International students arrive caring about sustainability but learning a new city all at once — unfamiliar supermarkets, share-house kitchens, Myki, bin systems, budgets, language. Sustainability is rarely the first thing that fits.

THE BET

Information helps. Belonging helps more. Students don't need another standard to fail — they need peers who've been a few months ahead, and habits that fit a new life.

I I'm not designing for students who don't care. I'm designing for the version of myself who cared, but spent the first months just figuring out where to buy rice.

— ZE, ON WHY THIS PROTOTYPE EXISTS

§ Three everyday entry points

Chapter one

Food waste

The bulk-pack problem: shopping for one in a system built for families.

- Two-meals-from-one-shop planning
- Share-house fridge etiquette & "use first" zones
- End-of-day market timing (Queen Vic, South Melbourne)
- Repurposing leftovers across cuisines

Chapter two

Transport

When the cheapest, lowest-carbon option is also the most confusing one.

- Myki confidence beyond the first tap-on
- Reading PTV routes without anxiety
- Walking & cycling: safe routes near campus
- When ride-share is the wrong reflex

Chapter three

Consumption

First-semester buying is where most regret — and most waste — lives.

- Op-shops & second-hand near student hubs
- Borrow-don't-buy for one-semester needs
- The "wait two weeks" rule for non-essentials
- Buy Nothing & share groups by suburb

EXAMPLE RESOURCE

A 5-step food waste starter

- 01 Plan two flexible meals before you shop.
- 02 Buy ingredients that cross at least two dishes.
- 03 Split bulk items with housemates on day one.
- 04 Keep a "use first" shelf at the front of the fridge.
- 05 Turn the week's leftovers into one wildcard meal.

WORKSHOP PROTOTYPE

Sustainable Student Living, Melbourne

60 minutes · peer-led · students leave with one habit to test that week

- 10' What's been confusing? (round-robin)
- 15' Food waste & low-cost cooking
- 15' Transport & everyday consumption
- 10' Pick one habit. Tell one person.
- 10' Feedback. What didn't land?

§ How I'd test it through Wattle

Step 01

Listen

Sit down with 8–10 international students. Find the real barriers, not the ones I assume.

Step 02

Prototype

One short digital guide and one workshop deck. Built to be edited, not defended.

Step 03

Pilot

Run one workshop. Watch where people lean in, where they check their phones.

Step 04

Improve

Cut what didn't land. Find one student who'd co-lead the next session.

Success looks like A student leaves a workshop with one habit they actually try that week — and a face they can text when they get stuck.